

Part 2 of 3

Towards an Extra Layer of Security: Activating Two-Factor Authentication



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In the first part of this article, last month, we learnt what two-factor authentication (TFA) is and its three types. Now, let us see how we can activate TFA for various websites and applications.

As secure as TFA is, unfortunately till date, you cannot use it everywhere on the web. However, most websites have recently implemented it, especially banking-sector websites, Gmail, Facebook, Twitter, Dropbox, Microsoft products like Xbox Live, OneDrive, Yahoo! Mail, Amazon web services, WordPress, DreamHost, LastPass, and many more.

Apple

In March 2013, Apple offered a consumer-oriented two-step authentication service to help customers secure their Apple IDs against hacking. This new feature disallows unauthorised changes to iCloud or iTunes accounts. It also disallows hackers, who steal Apple IDs, from purchasing digital content or hardware using credit card details



Fig. 10: Two-step verification for an Apple ID (Credit: Apple)



Fig. 11.1: Two-step verification for a Google account (Credit: Google/Gmail)

stored in the customers' iTunes and Apple Store accounts. Apple's web services do not distribute tokens. Instead, they send pass codes (typically as SMSes) to users' registered mobile phone numbers. Optional TFA sends the pass code to an iOS device (iPhone or iPad) via Find My iPhone app's notification feature. Fig. 10 shows how



Fig. 11.2: Step 1 in two-step verification for a Google account (Credit: Google/Gmail)

2-step verification adds an extra layer of security to your Google Account

In addition to your username and password, you'll enter a code that Google will send you via text, voice call, or our mobile app.

How it works

- 1** Enter your password
Whenever you sign in to Google you'll enter your username and password as usual.
 - 2** Enter a code from your phone
Then, you'll be asked for a code that will be sent to you via text, voice call, or our mobile app.
- Keep it simple**
During sign in, you can tell us not to ask for a code again on that particular computer. You'll still be covered, because we'll ask for codes when you or anyone else tries to sign in to your account from other computers.

Why you should use 2-step verification

2-step verification drastically reduces the chances of having the personal information in your Google Account stolen by someone else. Why? Because bad guys would have to not only get your password and your username, they'd have to get a hold of your phone.

Fig. 11.3: Step 2 in two-step verification for a Google account (Credit: Google/Gmail)